Of course, not all dogmas are equally harmful. Just as some religious beliefs have benefited humanity, so also have some secular dogmas. This is particularly true of the doctrine of human rights. The only place rights exist is in the stories humans invent and tell one another. These stories were enshrined as a self-evident dogma during the struggle against religious bigotry and autocratic governments. Though it isn't true that humans have a natural right to life or liberty, belief in this story curbed the power of authoritarian regimes, protected minorities from harm, and safeguarded billions from the worst consequences of poverty and violence. It thereby contributed to the happiness and welfare of humanity probably more than any other doctrine in history.

Yet it is still a dogma. Thus article 19 of the United Nations Declaration of Human Rights says that 'Everyone has the right to freedom of opinion and expression'. If we understand this is a political demand ('everyone *should* have the right to freedom of opinion'), this is perfectly sensible. But if we believe that each and every Sapiens is naturally endowed with a 'right to freedom of opinion', and that censorship therefore violates some law of nature, we miss the truth about humanity. As long as you define yourself as 'an individual possessing inalienable natural rights', you will not know who you really are, and you will not understand the historical forces that shaped your society and your own mind (including your belief in 'natural rights').

Such ignorance perhaps mattered little in the twentieth century, when people were busy fighting Hitler and Stalin. But it might become fatal in the twenty-first century, because biotechnology and artificial intelligence now seek to change the very meaning of humanity. If we are committed to the right to life, does that imply we should use biotechnology to overcome death? If we are committed to the right to liberty, should we empower algorithms that decipher and fulfil our hidden desires? If all humans enjoy equal human rights, do superhumans enjoy super-rights? Secular people will find it difficult to engage with such questions as long as they are committed to a dogmatic belief in 'human rights'.

The dogma of human rights was shaped in previous centuries as a weapon against the Inquisition, the *ancien régime*, the Nazis and the KKK. It is hardly equipped to deal with superhumans, cyborgs and super-intelligent computers. While human rights movements have developed a very impressive arsenal of arguments and defences against religious biases and human tyrants, this arsenal hardly protects us against consumerist excesses and technological utopias.

Acknowledging the shadow